Read accessible description

Raising awareness

Carson was not the first person to notice the harmful effects of DDT. There were a few early dissenters, including nature writer Edwin Way Teale, who warned that a spray with the indiscriminate impact of DDT could upset the balance of nature. In 1945, the director of the US Fish and Wildlife Service (FWS), Dr Clarence Cottam, stated that caution was essential in the use of DDT because the true impact of the product was not yet fully understood. The following year, Fred Bishop, writing in the *American Journal of Public Health,* stressed that DDT must not be allowed to get into foods or be ingested by accident.

Various scientific studies and reports also raised concerns. For example, in 1945 the US government published a study that found traces of DDT in the milk of cows sprayed with the chemical. It recommended that farmers use “safe alternative substitute insecticides” to control flies and lice on cattle. Carson’s longstanding position as editor-in-chief at the FWS until 1952 meant that she had access to a great many of these reports; she found them to be very disturbing reading.

Since the research was rather scattered and by no means accessible for the general reader, Carson resolved to gather what material she could find and present it in a way that the ordinary non-scientist could understand. As she made progress with the writing of *Silent Spring*, it became clear to her that she had a moral duty to make the information public. As well as documenting the hazards of indiscriminate pesticide use, Carson dared to suggest that the chemical companies were putting profits before people and that the government might even be colluding with them, knowingly or otherwise, by failing to regulate the industry effectively.